

If you notice sick or dead birds or other animals, you should not touch them. If there are multiple sick or dead birds or other animals, take photos or a video.

Record your location and report it to the 24-hour Emergency Animal Disease Hotline on 1800 675 888.

Veterinarians play a critical role in early detection and reporting of bird flu.

Keep watch for signs of bird flu

H5 high pathogenicity avian influenza (HPAI) clade 2.3.4.4.b has been detected overseas in a range of bird species. It has also been detected in marine and land mammals.

Signs of H5 bird flu in birds include:

- sudden death
- lethargy or reluctance to walk, eat or drink
- droopy appearance or ruffled feathers
- head or limb swelling
- bruising of the wattle, comb, feet or skin
- respiratory signs such as panting, nasal discharge or sneezing
- diarrhoea
- unusual head or neck posture, incoordination, inability to walk or stand
- unusual reduction in egg production

Dogs and cats

H5 bird flu is infrequent in cats and dogs overseas. When it occurs, there is usually a history of dogs or cats being exposed to sick or dead birds, other animals infected with avian influenza virus, consumption of raw pet food or unpasteurised (raw) milk.

Signs may be subtle or mistaken for other illnesses.

Signs can vary between species and may include:

- fever
- lethargy
- decreased appetite
- reddened or inflamed eyes
- discharge from eyes and nose
- coughing or sneezing
- difficulty breathing
- neurological signs, like tremors, seizures, incoordination, or blindness
- death

Reporting and sample collection

Bird flu is a notifiable animal disease. You must report it if you suspect a bird or other animal is infected.

Report to the 24-hour Emergency Animal Disease Hotline on 1800 675 888.

Check with your state or territory government biosecurity agency for advice on:

- sample collection and submission requirements
- personal protective equipment (PPE) and biosecurity precautions.

Protect yourself

If you handle sick or dead birds or other animals, take steps to protect yourself and your staff.

Find out more from the [Australian Centre for Disease Control](#).

Prepare your clinic

Now is the time to ensure you are prepared for H5 bird flu. Make sure you:

- know the signs
- follow your state or territory's guidelines
- use appropriate infection control measures
- prepare protocols for your staff and facility
- have sufficient PPE available.

Resources

For more information on how to prepare for H5 bird flu, a range of resources are available to support veterinarians.

- [Guidelines for Veterinary Personal Biosecurity](#) (Australian Veterinary Association)
- [HPAI Advice for veterinarians and animal health professionals](#) (Wildlife Health Australia)
- [CDNA national guidelines for avian influenza – protecting people who work with birds and wildlife](#) (Department of Health, Disability and Ageing)
- [Bird flu toolkit for people who work with birds](#) (Australian Centre for Disease Control)
- [Avian Influenza - Information for Private Veterinarians](#) (NSW Department of Primary Industries and Regional Development)

Download

- [National H5 high pathogenicity avian influenza guidelines for veterinarians \(PDF 1.3 MB\)](#)
- [National H5 high pathogenicity avian influenza guidelines for veterinarians \(DOCX 5.6 MB\)](#)

Not all the above documents were prepared by the department and may therefore fail to meet accessibility standards. For assistance and more information contact the AHC Secretariat at ahc@aff.gov.au.

Print resource for client use

State and territory guidance

Find more guidance and resources from your state and territory government biosecurity agency:

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/pests-diseases-weeds/animal/avian-influenza/veterinarians>